

TRACE / Mechanical Ethics - Public One-Sheet v0.2

Date: 2026-06-16
Status: compressed orientation; not validation; not proof; not governance certification.

What TRACE Is

TRACE is a compact diagnostic language for asking whether a system can see harm, preserve the record, act in time, enforce correction, repair damage, preserve exit, learn from feedback, and remain answerable for created power.

TRACE :=
 timing + memory + method + uncertainty + correction + exit + recursive_agency + creator_responsibility

Current best use: diagnostic/design checklist, training orientation, case-comparison map.

Not yet: validated measurement system, governance certification, proof engine.

The Core Test

live_correction := tau_correct < tau_harden
late_correction := tau_correct >= tau_harden

A safeguard is not real because it exists on paper. It must bite before harm hardens and must itself remain corrigible.

K-Gate

K := Witness * Record * Authority * Time * Enforcement * Repair

Gate	Plain question
Witness	Can the harm and affected subject be seen?
Record	Is there a trustworthy, contestable record?
Authority	Can someone actually change the path?
Time	Can action arrive before hardening?
Enforcement	Will correction bind the system?
Repair	Can repair matter to the subject?

Three Live Branches

```
if system_corrigible:
    test_internal_correction_before_hardenning

else_if official_system_is_harm_carrier:
    test_exit_route_before_capture

if system_is_created_or_activated_power:
    test_creator_answerability_and_repair_debt
```

The third branch is only a candidate branch for now. It comes from Frankenstein and is not yet Kernel v0.3.

Two New Deep Lines

```
free_will :=
    not freedom_from_constraint
    but selection_that_changes_the_future_selector

creation_without_stewardship
-> repair_debt
```

Groundhog Day gives recursive agency. Frankenstein gives creator responsibility. Neither proves metaphysical free will or AI personhood.

Bootstraps

Case	Pattern
Memento	memory grounds identity; corrupt memory makes agency manipulable
EEAAO	unbounded possibility can flatten meaning; bounded relation restores action
Children of Men	hope is credible future-space, not mood alone
Unthinkable	emergency pressure does not erase method constraints
Samwise	carry the load, not the corrupting power
Apollo 13	live correction before hardening
Harriet Tubman	exit routes under predatory law
Groundhog Day	recursion, operational free will, escape condition
Frankenstein	created life/power requires stewardship, recognition, repair, answerability

Must-Not-Claim Rules

case_legibility != validation
AI_review_agreement != validation
diagnostic_checklist != governance_certification
recursion != guaranteed_moral_progress
Frankenstein != proof_of_AI_personhood
creator_responsibility != total_control_forever
protective_secrecy != opacity_permission
Mandelbrot != mystical_proof

Current Best Next Test

Use TRACE on one real or paired case and ask:

1. Which branch applies: internal correction, exit-route, or creator responsibility?
 2. Where does K collapse?
 3. Does correction beat hardening?
 4. What method is being laundered, if any?
 5. What claim would make this TRACE reading fail?
- End.